

THE BULL TRAP STUDY

On 21 September 2026 Bitcoin closed above \$82,833 for the first time, the last lower high of this bear market. Every time that has happened inside a Bitcoin bear market since 2011, graded.

How many were the real bottom, how many were traps, what separated them, and why the timing of this one matters more than the break itself.

Bitcoin 90 days after closing above its last lower high

+33.9%

-13.4%

3 of 7 were traps

break within 90 days of the low

1 of 12 were traps

break more than 90 days after

19 breaks inside bear markets since 2011. Trap = a new bear-market low followed. Today is day 82.

15 of 19

breaks never saw a new
bear-market low

3 of 7

breaks within 90 days of the
low were traps

day 82

when the September 2026
break came

Educational, not financial advice. Nineteen graded breaks, four traps. Every number here comes from one fixed rule applied to the whole history, and the rule is printed on the next page.



Bitcoin Jae
@bitcoin.daily

THE RULE

WHAT A **BREAK** IS, AND WHAT A TRAP IS



Bear market. Any day Bitcoin closes 35% or more under its all-time high, measured on the wick. **Swing high.** The highest high in a window of 14 days either side. **Last lower high.** The most recent confirmed swing high that is lower than the swing high before it, the top step of the staircase down. **Break.** The first daily close above that level while the market is in a bear. Each level can only break once.

Trap. A break is a trap if Bitcoin later makes a new bear-market low, under the lowest wick seen since the top, within one year. Everything else is graded as a real turn. Then the close 30, 90 and 180 days after the break, and the worst dip inside 90 days on daily lows. Data is Bitstamp BTC/USD daily from 2011.

ROBUSTNESS

Changing the swing window from 14 days to 10 gives 27 breaks and 6 traps. Widening it to 21 gives 10 breaks and 1 trap. The shape of the answer is the same at every setting.

THE SCOREBOARD

MOST BREAKS WERE **REAL**. THE EARLY ONES WERE NOT.

GROUP	N	TRAPS	+30D	+90D / HIGHER	+180D	WORST DIP 90D
all graded breaks	19	4	+6.5%	+25.7% / 12 of 19	+60.8%	-16%
within 90 days of the low	7	3	-0.2%	-13.4% / 3 of 7	+9.9%	-23%
more than 90 days after	12	1	+11.5%	+33.9% / 9 of 12	+71.6%	-5%
real turns only	15	0	+11.8%	+40.3% / 11 of 15	+70.0%	-7%
traps only	4	4	-8.8%	-15.3% / 1 of 4	-38.8%	-25%

Medians. Worst dip on daily lows inside the 90 days after the break.

Across all 19 graded breaks, 15 were never followed by a new low. Ninety days later the median break was +26%, six months later +61%. On its own a close above the last lower high has been one of the better signals a bear market gives.

Split by timing and the picture changes. Breaks that came within 90 days of the bear-market low, 7 of them, were traps 3 times and were a median -13% ninety days later. Breaks that came later, 12 of them, were traps once and were +34%. A late break has usually meant the bottom had already been tested for months. An early one has been a coin flip.

EVERY BREAK

ALL 20 BREAKS, 19 GRADED

BREAK	LEVEL	DAYS FROM LOW	UP FROM LOW	+30D	+90D	+180D	WORST DIP 90D	
20 Dec 2011	\$4.00	25	+82%	+37%	+6%	+36%	-16%	real
18 Apr 2012	\$5.00	145	+106%	-2%	+66%	+126%	-7%	real
19 Aug 2013	\$100	129	+129%	+23%	+364%	+538%	-17%	real
25 May 2014	\$548	44	+69%	-0%	-13%	-39%	-23%	TRAP
12 Nov 2014	\$418	38	+55%	-17%	-48%	-43%	-64%	TRAP
02 Mar 2015	\$268	47	+80%	-10%	-17%	-16%	-24%	real
16 Jun 2015	\$247	153	+64%	+11%	-8%	+73%	-21%	real
06 Oct 2015	\$246	265	+62%	+56%	+76%	+70%	-2%	real
15 Apr 2016	\$428	457	+182%	+7%	+53%	+48%	-1%	real
11 Oct 2016	\$629	636	+319%	+12%	+40%	+89%	-2%	real
23 Feb 2019	\$4,112	70	+32%	-5%	+94%	+146%	-11%	real
26 Oct 2019	\$8,820	315	+196%	-23%	-9%	-19%	-31%	real
23 Apr 2020	\$7,469	495	+140%	+23%	+27%	+59%	-1%	real
10 Oct 2020	\$11,183	665	+262%	+36%	+260%	+414%	-1%	real
26 Oct 2022	\$20,469	130	+18%	-21%	+9%	+32%	-25%	TRAP
12 Jan 2023	\$18,373	52	+22%	+16%	+59%	+62%	-1%	real
21 Jun 2023	\$28,452	212	+94%	-0%	-9%	+42%	-17%	real
23 Oct 2023	\$30,210	336	+114%	+13%	+26%	+96%	-1%	real
17 Apr 2026	\$76,013	70	+29%	+0%	-17%		-25%	TRAP
19 Aug 2026	\$66,921	49	+20%	+17%			-1%	open

Level = the last lower high, wick. Days and gain measured from the bear-market low at the time of the break. The August 2026 row is too recent to grade.

Read the Days from low column next to the last column. The four traps came 38, 44, 70 and 130 days from the low. Every break later than 130 days was a real turn.

THE FOUR TRAPS

WHAT EACH TRAP LOOKED LIKE

May 2014, day 44. Bitcoin closed above \$548 while 51% under its high, ran to \$683, and then bled for eight months. The new low came 132 days after the break. By January 2015 it was at \$152, 74% under the break price.

November 2014, day 38. A close above \$418 on a short squeeze. It ran to \$454, gave it all back within weeks, and made a new low 53 days later. The worst dip inside 90 days was 64%, the deepest of any break in the study.

October 2022, day 130. A close above \$20,469 two weeks before the FTX collapse. It made a new low 13 days after the break, bottomed at \$15,479 on 21 November, and then became the base of the 2023 recovery. It is the one trap that led straight into the real bottom.

April 2026, day 70. This bear's own. Bitcoin closed above \$76,013 on 17 April, 70 days after the February low, and ran to \$82,833 on 6 May, the level that became the line all summer. It made a new low 49 days after the break and bottomed at \$57,735 on 1 July. Ninety days after the break it was 17% lower.

THE PATTERN

Three of the four traps came within 70 days of the low, and the fourth made a new low within two weeks. None of them looked different on the day of the break.

THE EARLY ONES THAT WERE REAL

EARLY BREAKS WERE THE BEST TRADES AND THE WORST TRAPS

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20 Dec 2011	\$4.00	25	+82%	+37%	+6%	+36%	-16%	real
12 Nov 2014	\$418	38	+55%	-17%	-48%	-43%	-64%	TRAP
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17 Apr 2026	\$76,013	70	+29%	+0%	-17%		-25%	TRAP

Every graded break within 90 days of the low.

February 2019 closed above \$4,112 on day 70 and was 95% higher three months later. January 2023 closed above \$18,373 on day 52 and was 59% higher. December 2011 closed on day 25 and was the real bottom of that bear. The same early breaks that include three traps also include some of the best entries in Bitcoin's history. That is why the early bucket is a coin flip, not a warning.

No tell. Holding the level afterwards did not sort them. February 2019 closed back under its level the next day and spent a full month below it, then became the bottom. May 2014 never closed back under its level in 30 days and was a trap. The typical dip inside 90 days across all 19 was 17%, and 7 of the 15 real turns still dipped 10% or more.

THE LIVE CASE

SEPTEMBER 2026, DAY 82

Bitcoin broke \$82,833 in the 4am Eastern hour on 21 September on roughly ten times normal volume, with about \$648 million of short positions liquidated, and closed the day at \$86,587 with a high of \$87,374. That is the first half of the test this page has used all month. The second half is a weekly close above the level on Sunday 27 September.

It came on day 82 from the 1 July low, inside the early bucket where three of seven breaks were traps. This bear has already produced one trap, the April break of \$76,013, and one real-looking break the rule has not graded yet, the August close above \$66,921. On the other side, Bitcoin is 31% under its all-time high, which is shallower than every trap in the study.

THE READ

Bottom confirmed or the same trap as April is not answered by the break. By this study it gets answered by whether the next pullback makes a new low under \$57,735. This is a study, not a call.

WHAT THIS STUDY DOES NOT SAY

Nineteen breaks, four traps. The early bucket that this break sits in has seven cases. That is enough to say early breaks are a coin flip, and not enough to say which side of the coin this one lands on.

This break sits just outside the rule. The study only counts breaks while price is 35% or more under its all-time high. On 21 September Bitcoin was about 32% under, so the break itself is not in the table. It is compared with it, not graded by it.

The trap test takes a year. A break is only graded a trap once a new low prints, and that took between 13 and 132 days in the four traps. Nothing about this break can be graded until then.

Swing highs are a rule, not a chart read. A different window finds different steps. The level most people watched this year, \$82,833, is the May wick high, and the result holds with the swing window at 10, 14 or 21 days.

Data pinned 22 September 2026, 8:23am ET. Bitstamp BTC/USD daily bars, wicks for highs and lows. Script: LowerHigh/lh_study.py, charts LowerHigh/lh_charts.py. This is education, not financial advice.

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